

Urdu, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to contemporary Urdu

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Starter edition — ten short lessons in three cumulative chapters.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/urdu/lessons/

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Urdu. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the letters, sounds, and grammar it needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends with a retrieval prompt. Read Urdu from right to left, but do not memorize an alphabet before you meet useful language.

Urdu is traditionally printed in the descending Nastaliq style. This starter edition uses the vendored Noto Naskh Arabic font as a legible, deterministic fallback while a static Nastaliq font is evaluated separately. The language, joining behavior, and right-to-left order are Urdu; the type style is labelled honestly rather than silently presented as Nastaliq.

Urdu vocabulary makes several histories visible. Its grammar and much everyday vocabulary are Indo-Aryan and closely related to Hindi, while Persian and Arabic have contributed a large literary and formal layer. Etymology here is a memory aid, not a claim that a borrowed word is any less fully Urdu today.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions establish right-to-left reading, joining, omitted short vowels, long vowels, respectful *jī*, and one Urdu nasal sign. Companion lessons: UR-C01-*.md.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Urdu runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ā long ā, م *m*. Letters usually join inside a word. The tall ل does not connect to the following letter, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are due yet.

Where the expression came from

Salām is a greeting and the word “peace.” Urdu received it through the Persian-Arabic literary world. Its consonants **s–l–m** belong to a Semitic family concerned with peace, safety, and wholeness. Persian *salām*, Arabic *salām*, and Hebrew *shalom* make the historical family especially visible.

Use it now

Say سلام to begin a friendly exchange. For now the safest reply is the same word: A says سلام; B answers سلام. One useful move is enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries long *ā*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salām* once.

1.2 شکریہ (*shukriyā*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Urdu normally leaves short vowels unmarked. Read the visible guide: ش *sh*, ک *k*, ر *r*, ی *y/i*, ہ final *h*-shape. The learned whole supplies the short *u* and *i*, while the ending is pronounced long *ā*. First remember one joined word, not every possible letter form.

Where the expression came from

The central consonants **sh–k–r** belong to the Arabic family for gratitude; Arabic *shukran* is a close comparison. Urdu *shukriyā* reflects its long Persian-Arabic lexical history and is an ordinary modern Urdu expression.

Use it now

Build a two-step chain: سلام *salām* — hello; شکریہ *shukriyā* — thank you. Keep the second word in three light beats: *shuk-ri-yā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which new letter begins شکریہ? Point to ش, say *sh*, then produce *salām* — *shukriyā* without looking.

1.3 جی ہاں (*jī hā*) — yes, respectfully**Read only what this expression needs**

This answer has two small words. In جی, ج gives *j* and ی stretches the vowel to *ī*. In ہاں, the final ہ is **nūn ghunna**: it nasalizes long *ā* rather than adding a strong English *n*. Let a little air pass through the nose.

Use it now

ہاں means “yes.” Adding جی makes the response attentive and respectful; جی can also answer by itself. Learn the safely courteous whole first: جی ہاں *jī hā*.

One-minute checkpoint

Which final sign nasalizes the vowel? Point to ں. Then answer politely: جی ہاں.

1.4 نہیں (*nahī*) — no, and later not**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse ہ, ی, and nasal ں; add ن *n* at the right edge. The result is نہیں *nahī*. Stretch *ī* slightly and nasalize it; do not add a separate forceful *n* at the end.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the Persian-Arabic vocabulary that opened the chapter, *nahī* belongs to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan core. Hindi *nahī* is the same spoken word written in a different script. The shared form previews close grammatical kinship without making Hindi script a prerequisite.

Use it now

As a complete answer, نہیں means “no.” Inside a later sentence it will also mean “not,” but that second job can wait. Contrast only: جی ہاں — yes; نہیں — no.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the chain hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, شکریہ, جی ہاں, نہیں in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds one sentence and one word-order fact: Urdu places the present copula at the end. Companion lesson: UR-C02-mera-naam.md.

2.1 میرا نام ... ہے — my name is ...

Read the Urdu phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

میرا نام سارا ہے۔
merā nām Sārā hai — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

Nearly every shape is recycled. میرا begins with م from سلام, then reuses ی, ر, and ا. نام reuses ن, ا, and م. In final ہے, the only new form is ے, called *barī ye*; here the whole word is pronounced *hai*. Learn that diphthong with the word.

Use it now

Assemble four slots:

1. میرا *merā* — my;
2. نام *nām* — name;
3. your name;
4. ہے *hai* — is.

The reusable pattern is **my + name + NAME + is**. Urdu places *hai* at the end. Replace Sara with your name and keep every other slot.

Where the expression came from

Nām continues an old Indo-Aryan form related to Sanskrit *nāman* and, much farther back, English *name*. The possessive *merā* and copula *hai* also belong to Urdu’s inherited grammar. The sentence therefore follows the Indo-Aryan layer that Urdu shares closely with Hindi, even though Urdu writes it in the Perso-Arabic script.

One-minute checkpoint

Where does “is” go? At the end. Point to **ہے**, then replace Sara with your own name and say the full four-slot sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Urdu possessives agree with the noun they describe; *merā* has this form because *nām* is grammatically masculine, not because of the speaker’s gender. That rule, other possessive forms, and the rest of the copula paradigm belong to later lessons. The fixed introduction works for every speaker now.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

This chapter is generated from the canonical micro-lessons used by Language Ladder. Each section stays independently resumable and preserves the authored prerequisite order.

3.1 آپ / تم / تو — three relationships inside “you”

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Say **merā nām ... hai** with your own name. To ask the other person’s name, begin with the respectful form.

You’ll want to know first — three forms

Urdu	read	use
آپ	<i>āp</i>	respectful: a new adult, elder, or anyone you wish to honor
تم	<i>tum</i>	familiar: friends and peers
تو	<i>tū</i>	intimate, or downward; unsafe as a beginner default

آپ begins with Ā, an alif carrying the long *ā* mark, then پ *p*. تم and تو share *t*. In تو, و carries long *ū*.

Grammar Lens: choose the relationship first

English flattened these choices into one *you*. Urdu keeps three. Use **āp** in a first meeting. Move to **tum** when the relationship supports familiarity. Save **tū** for relationships where you already know it is welcome; used badly, it can sound belittling.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tum/tū belong to the old Indo-European familiar-“you” family: Sanskrit *tvam*, English **thou**, and Latin *tū* are relatives. **Āp** followed another route: a word connected with “self/oneself” became honorific address.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: a new adult — **āp**]
- [YOU SAY: a friend — **tum**]
- [YOU SAY: the old family — **tum**, **tvam**, **thou**]

Wrap-up recall

Which form is safest when unsure? (**Āp**.) Which familiar forms share history with English *thou*? (**Tum/tū**.)
Source: *Basic Urdu*: Cultural Notes.

3.2 کیا — what

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Which “you” opens a respectful first meeting? (آپ, *āp*.) Now add the question word.

You’ll want to know first — کیا

کیا — *kyā* — **what**

Read right to left: ک *k*, ی supplying the *y* glide here, then ! long *ā*. The same ی carried long *ī* in جی and نہیں. Its job depends on the word; here the learned shape is *kyā*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Urdu **kyā** and Hindi **kyā** are the same inherited Indo-Aryan word in different scripts. Their history reaches Sanskrit *kim* and the old Indo-European *k/kw-* question family behind English **wh-** words such as *what*, *who*, and *which*. The bridge helps memory; Urdu کیا remains the form you must read here.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **kyā** — what]
- [YOU READ: کیا as **k** + **yā**]
- [YOU SAY: the family — **kyā**, **what**, **who**, **which**]

Wrap-up recall

Which letter acts as *y* here but as long *ī* in جی؟ (ی.) What does کیا mean? (**What**.)

3.3 آپ کا نام — ask a name respectfully

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Recall **āp** “you,” **kyā** “what,” and the answer **merā nām ... hai**. The question reuses all three.

The exchange

آپ کا نام — *āp kā nām kyā hai?* — **What is your name?**

Build it in spoken order:

you + **kā** + name + what + is?

Āp kā means “your” in this frame. The possessive form agrees with the thing owned: **nām** is masculine singular, so use **kā**. Keep that one pairing; the full *kā/kī/ke* system can wait. As in your answer, **hai** stays at the end.

Script: the question mark

Urdu ends the question with ؟, curved for a right-to-left line. Begin at آپ on the right and reach the punctuation at the far left.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **āp k̄ā nām kyā hai?**]
- [YOU SAY: ask, then answer — **merā nām ... hai**]
- [YOU POINT: to ؟ at the end]

Wrap-up recall

Ask once without romanization. Where does **hai** remain? (At the end.)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions*.

3.4 آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی — pleased to meet you

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Ask **āp k̄ā nām kyā hai?** and answer **merā nām ... hai**. This fixed response now closes the meeting.

The exchange

آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ *āp se mil kar khushī huī* **Pleased to meet you.**

For now, hold three meaning-sized chunks:

- **āp se** — with you
- **mil kar** — having met
- **khushī huī** — happiness happened

That yields the memorable literal picture: “**Having met you, happiness happened.**” The phrase is one social move; later lessons can generalize *se*, *-kar*, and past agreement one at a time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Khushī “happiness” comes from Persian **khosh/khush** “pleasant, happy.” **Mil** “meet” and **huī** “happened” belong to Urdu’s inherited Indo-Aryan grammar. The sentence therefore joins Urdu’s two major historical layers without becoming any less ordinary Urdu.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: **āp se | mil kar | khushī huī** in three beats]
- [YOU SAY: the literal picture — “having met you, happiness happened”]
- [YOU SAY: which word came through Persian — **khushī**]

Wrap-up recall

Say the response once as a whole. Which chunk means “happiness happened”? (**Khushī huī.**)

Source: *Basic Urdu: Greetings and Introductions.*

3.5 Practice — a complete Urdu name exchange

Warm-up. [PAUSE 2s] Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salām!* B: سلام! — *Salām!* A: آپ کا نام کیا ہے؟ — *Āp kā nām kyā hai?* B: میرا نام سارا ہے۔ — *Merā nām Sārā hai.* A: آپ سے مل کر خوشی ہوئی۔ — *Āp se mil kar khushī huī.* B: شکریہ۔ — *Shukriyā.*

Every line is already known. **Āp** keeps the meeting respectful; **hai** stays at the end of both name sentences; ؟ ends the question at the line’s left.

Guided Practice

- [YOU SAY: both voices, using your own name]
- [YOU SAY: the exchange again without romanization]
- [YOU SAY: only the three name moves — question, answer, response]

Wrap-up recall

Run the meeting once from **salām** to **shukriyā**. If a line stalls, review only that micro-lesson.

Sources for this starter edition

Script descriptions follow Northwestern University’s open Zero Zabar Urdu-alphabet materials. The companion Markdown lessons are the canonical short-practice source for this edition.